

REPENTANCE: SURRENDERING SELF-RULE

Turning to God Means Abandoning Your Claim to Yourself

Repentance is the willing abandonment of sin and self-rule in the same trusting surrender by which the sinner entrusts himself to Jesus Christ.



BIG IDEA

Repentance turns from sin and self-rule to God in trusting surrender to Christ.

KEY SCRIPTURE

Acts 17:22-31

ALSO READ

Luke 15:17-24

MEMORY VERSE

MARK 1:15b

"Repent ye, and believe the gospel."

MAIN QUESTION

What Does It Mean to Repent?

45 MINUTES

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SESSION SNAPSHOT



SESSION GOALS

- Define repentance as a real change of direction.
- Identify self-rule as the allegiance being abandoned.
- See repentance and faith as one turning.
- Distinguish repentance from sorrow, promises, and reform.

A

OPENING ACTIVITY: "SORRY OR TURNED?"

1

READ FOUR STATEMENTS (2 MIN)

Write: I hate the consequences. I feel terrible. I will try harder. I no longer claim the right to rule myself. Ask which sounds most like repentance.

2

NAME WHAT IS MISSING (2 MIN)

Regret, sorrow, and promises may be sincere, but each can leave the person travelling in the same direction under the same authority.

3

TRACE THE SON'S TURN (2 MIN)

Read Luke 15:17-20. The son recognizes the truth, leaves the far country, returns to his father, and abandons his demand to live on his own terms.

4

CONNECT THE GOSPEL (2 MIN)

Read Mark 1:15. Jesus does not call people merely to feel bad. The Gospel announces God's authority and summons them to repent and believe.

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LEADER GUARDRAIL

Do not present repentance as cleaning up before coming to Christ, a separate work that earns forgiveness, or a public display of emotion. Repentance and saving faith are not two transactions. They are the same surrender viewed from what is abandoned and whom is trusted.

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PREPARE

- Bible
- Board or paper
- Two colored markers
- Student handouts
- Review Session 8

Repentance is not feeling differently while continuing to rule yourself.

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CORE TEACHING

1

THE GOSPEL CALLS FOR A TURN

Mark 1:14-15

Jesus announces God's good news and rightful authority, then commands people to repent and believe. Repentance is not vague self-improvement; it is a response to Christ and His Gospel.

EMPHASIZE: The summons rests on what God has done, not what we achieve.

2

REPENTANCE ABANDONS SELF-RULE

Acts 17:22-31

Sin grows from the claim that life belongs to us. To repent is to turn from sin, falsehood, and every rival allegiance by giving up the right to define and direct life apart from God.

EMPHASIZE: The central surrender is authority, not merely selected habits.

3

REPENTANCE TURNS TO GOD

Luke 15:17-24

The lost son does more than recognize his ruin. He rises, leaves the far country, and returns to his father. Repentance is a real change of direction toward restored relationship.

EMPHASIZE: Turning from self-rule means returning to the One we rejected.

4

REPENTANCE AND FAITH ARE ONE TURN

Acts 20:20-21

Repentance names the turning from sin and former allegiance; faith names the turning to Christ in trusting reliance. Both are contained in surrender to Him.

EMPHASIZE: Do not separate what Scripture holds together.

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DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1

Why is feeling sorry not the same as repentance?

Follow-up: Can sorrow leave your direction unchanged?

2

What does self-rule claim about your life?

Follow-up: Why is this deeper than individual bad habits?

3

What actions show the son's turn in Luke 15?

Follow-up: What authority does he stop claiming?

4

How are repentance and faith one turning?

Follow-up: What does each word emphasize?

5

Does repentance earn forgiveness by reforming life?

Follow-up: Where does forgiveness actually come from?

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WEEKLY REFLECTION

Read Luke 15:11-24. Trace the son's recognition, decision, and return.

- Where am I still claiming the right to rule myself?
- Am I merely sorry, or am I turning to Christ?

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PRIVATE CONVERSATION

Do not demand a public performance. If a student is ready to turn, help him speak honestly to God and entrust himself to Christ rather than repeat a formula.

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LEADER NOTES

- Direction, not emotion.
- Authority, not self-improvement.
- One turn with faith.
- Surrender does not merit grace.
- Fruit follows the root.

2

ONE TURN - TWO DIRECTIONS

REPENTANCE

Turning from sin, falsehood, and self-rule

FAITH

Turning to Jesus Christ in trusting reliance



Repentance turns from self-rule because faith entrusts the whole life to Christ.